A SKILL FOR CLAUDE CODE

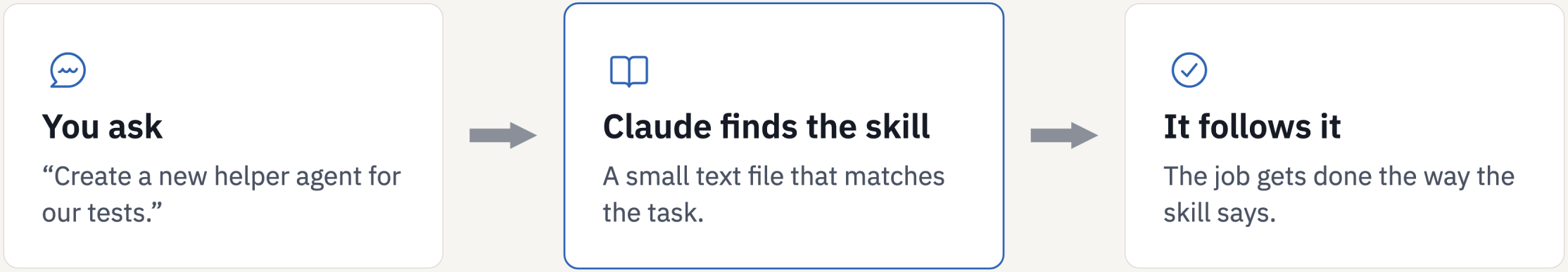
sonnet-lean

Cheaper AI helpers in Claude Code.
Set them up once, same results.

Henrique Telles · github.com/henriquetell/claude-skills

FIRST, WHAT IS A SKILL?

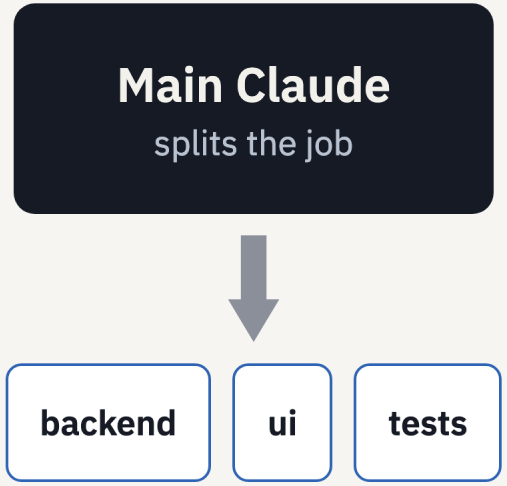
A skill is a short how-to that Claude reads when it needs it



Think of it as a checklist a senior colleague hands you for one specific job. You install it once, and Claude uses it on its own when that job comes up.

THE PROBLEM

Claude hands work to helper agents, and each one costs money



Each helper has a small settings file. Most people never touch it, so:

- **It reads things it doesn’t need**
- **It thinks harder than the job needs**
- **It uses the same model for every task**

WHAT SONNET-LEAN DOES

It sets your helpers up once, then gets out of the way

① ONCE, WHEN YOU CREATE A HELPER



Writes the right settings into the helper's file.

② EVERY TASK AFTER THAT



The helper just runs cheaper. Nothing extra to load.

WHAT IT CHANGES

A couple of lines in the helper’s file

TYPICAL

```
name: ui-helper
model: sonnet
skills:
  - data-rules
  - style-guide  # not used here
```

Less to read: only the skills this helper really uses.

AFTER SONNET-LEAN

```
name: ui-helper
model: sonnet
effort: medium
skills:
  - data-rules
```

The right effort: low for simple jobs, medium for normal coding, high for hard work.

TESTED ON A REAL PROJECT

Same result, about 15% cheaper per task



A real helper rebuilt a real feature from a browser game. Both setups passed all 10 of the project’s own tests.

HeroBrowser · cost per task at list price · 2 runs each

PICKING THE MODEL

Smaller when a test can check it, bigger only when it fails

Small, clear task → smaller model

−39%

Same result. A test catches it if the smaller model slips.

Hard task → bigger model?

3× · 17×

the cost, slower, and the same correct answer. Only upgrade after a check fails.

Smaller: Haiku vs Sonnet · Bigger: Opus and Fable vs Sonnet on a real game-engine change, all correct

HOW TO USE IT

Install once, then just ask

```
cp -R sonnet-lean ~/.claude/skills/
```

“Create a helper agent for our API work.”

“Why are my agents so expensive?”

“Set up which model each agent should use.”

Claude picks up the skill on its own for requests like these, or type **/sonnet-lean**.

THE TAKEAWAY

Set your helpers up once. Pay less on every task.

Less to read, the right effort, the right model. Same results.

github.com/henriquetell/claude-skills

Free · every number can be re-checked